04

LAND YOUR FIRST AI CLIENT · THE PACK

THE PRICING & OFFER GUIDE

Stop Undercharging

How to price a first client without freezing or lowballing, and how to build an offer that's easy to say yes to.

THE CORE PROBLEM

00 Why beginners bleed out on price

There are two ways to lose here, and almost everyone starting out picks one. Either you charge so little that the client assumes you're garbage and you burn yourself out for pennies, or you freeze and never say a number at all and the deal evaporates. Both come from the same place: you don't believe it's worth the money yet.

So let's fix the belief first. You're not charging for hours of work or lines of code. You're charging for an outcome, more leads captured, more time back, more money made. When you price against the value to their business instead of the effort it costs you, the numbers stop feeling scary.

> **THE REFRAME THAT FIXES EVERYTHING**
>
> Nobody buys a drill because they want a drill. They want a hole. Your client doesn't want "an AI system." They want to stop losing leads. Price the hole, not the drill. The hole is worth a lot more.

01 Price against their numbers, not yours

The single best pricing skill: make the price look small next to what the problem is costing them. You already gathered these numbers on the discovery call. Now you use them.

The math that sells itself

On the call you asked two things: what's a customer worth, and how many are they losing. That gives you their cost of doing nothing. Your price just has to be a fraction of that.

> EXAMPLE
>
> A customer is worth $1,500 to them. They're losing maybe 3 leads a week to unanswered after-hours calls. That's potentially thousands a month walking out the door. Against that, a setup fee and a monthly retainer isn't expensive, it's a bargain, and you can say so with a straight face.

When you frame it this way, you're not defending your price, you're pointing at their leak. The conversation shifts from "can I afford this" to "can I afford NOT to."

02 Build vs retainer (the two-part offer)

The model that works for this kind of service has two pieces, and understanding why is what turns a one-time gig into a real business.

The build fee (one-time)

The upfront work: setting it up, configuring it, launching it. This is a chunk of money paid once, usually split 50% up front and 50% on completion. The deposit is non-negotiable, it filters out tire-kickers and protects you.

The retainer (monthly, recurring)

The ongoing piece: hosting, maintenance, monitoring, tweaks, support. This is the part that actually builds you a business, because one-time fees mean you're always hunting for the next client. Recurring revenue means you stack income and sleep at night.

> **WHY THE RETAINER MATTERS MORE THAN THE BUILD**
>
> Ten clients paying you monthly is a real income you can count on. Ten one-time projects is ten times you had to start from zero. Always structure for recurring revenue, even if the monthly number is modest at first. Stacking beats hunting.

Why this also protects you

When the system lives on your infrastructure and the client pays monthly to keep it running, you have a natural relationship and a natural off-switch. Stop paying, it stops running. That keeps the recurring revenue honest and stops people from paying once and ghosting you forever.

03 What to charge as a beginner

Here's the honest part. There's no magic number, it depends on the service, the market, and the value. But beginners always ask "what do I put on the proposal," so here's how to think about it without lowballing yourself into the ground.

The floor

Never charge so little that you resent the work or the client assumes you're cheap for a reason. Pricing too low is a positioning mistake, not a nice gesture. It attracts the worst clients and repels the good ones. If a number feels a little uncomfortable to say out loud, you're probably close to right.

How to land on a number

1. **Start from their cost of doing nothing.** What's the leak worth per month? Your monthly should be a comfortable fraction of that.
2. **Make the build fee meaningful.** Enough that they're invested and you're paid for real work. A deposit that's too small means they don't take it seriously.
3. **Charge for the outcome, not your speed.** If you get fast and it takes you two hours, that's your edge to keep, not a reason to charge two hours' worth. They're paying for the result.

> **SET YOUR REAL NUMBERS**
>
> Decide your actual build fee and monthly retainer BEFORE your next call, and write them down. The worst thing you can do is invent a number live while nervous, that's when you lowball. Know your price cold so you say it without flinching.

04 Presenting price without flinching

How you say the number matters as much as the number. Say it plainly, then stop talking. The person who speaks first after the price loses, so don't let it be you.

HOW TO SAY IT

"So the setup is [build fee], and then it's [monthly] a month to keep it running, hosted, and maintained. We do half the setup up front to get started and the rest on launch. That work for you?"

Then silence. Don't apologize, don't justify, don't immediately offer a discount. You said the number, now let them respond. If you flinch, they flinch.

The first-client exception

It's fine to price your very first client a little lower in exchange for something valuable: a testimonial, a case study, permission to show the results. Just name it as a deliberate trade, not a panic discount.

HOW TO FRAME IT

"Since you'd be one of my first clients in [industry], I'll do [X] on the price. In exchange, if I knock it out of the park, I'd love a testimonial and to use the results as a case study. Fair trade?"

LAST THING

Your first client's real value isn't the check. It's the proof, the case study, and the referrals. Charge enough to be taken seriously, then over-deliver so hard they sell your next three clients for you. That's how this actually compounds.

THAT'S THE PACK

You've got the whole map.

Playbook for the plan. Swipe File for the words. Cheat Sheet for the call. Pricing Guide for the close. Now the only thing left is the part that actually matters: doing the outreach. Go.